

IN THE SHADOWS
(Far left) Three-time PM Nawaz Sharif, who wants PM Shehbaz to take a populist stance; left, army chief Gen. Qamar Javed Bajwa

cause the so-called torch-bearers of civilian supremacy are actually asking the military to intervene on their behalf rather than stay out of politics. While the battle of words heats up and the political situation gets more polarised, the key decisions could come, as before, from the judiciary. If Imran is convicted, even symbolically, he would be ineligible to contest elections. For now, Imran and his party deputies have obviously decided that the best defence is offence. They have been issuing warnings of dire situations should the worst happen.

TOUGH TASK FOR SHEHBAZ

Meanwhile, PM Shehbaz Sharif can only hope that he and his team can come to grips with the galloping inflation and the tottering economy before the general election. He is already under pressure from his self-exiled elder brother, three-time prime minister Nawaz Sharif, to take a more populist stance because of rising anger on the streets.

Shehbaz Sharif has been prime minister for only five months so far, but most of his time has been taken up lurching from one crisis to another, which has left the perception that the 'man of action' was himself struggling to find his feet as premier. Initially, the first priority for his coalition government was averting Pakistan defaulting and getting the stalled IMF programme back on track to secure the injection of much-needed funds. By his finance minister's own admission, the IMF made the government jump through a lot of hoops before resuming the programme after four months.

The extended ambiguity about the economy and politics that led to a massive slide in the rupee's value was not helped by dissension from within the Sharifs' Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz (PML-N)—it was clear that Nawaz and his charismatic daughter and political heir Maryam were not totally sold on the idea of eroding their political capital to fix the issues that Imran had left behind. In fact, the new government wasted about a month early on, seemingly unable to bring itself to unfreeze fuel prices and incur the wrath of the public. It was only when it became obvious that the IMF would not entertain a resumption without this and that other donors were waiting to take a lead from the IMF, and that this could lead to Pakistan going down the bankruptcy route like Sri Lanka, that the government finally hiked prices.

Then, Shehbaz's son Hamza, who had been nominated as chief minister of Pakistan's largest province, Punjab, in a badly assessed political move—because it reinforced the perception of nepotism within the PML-N—was ousted from the office after a judicial ruling against the manner of his election. Not being able to control Punjab is considered anathema for any federal government. But Shehbaz had to swallow the bitter pill of, in effect, only controlling the centre while PTI now controls both Punjab and KP and PML-N's coalition allies control Sindh and Balochistan.

With the IMF programme finally on track and a devastating default averted, however, the Shehbaz government has a little bit more breathing room to focus on other matters, particularly the high inflation grievously hurting the people. There is still hope that the PM and his team have a better understanding of economic matters than the government that preceded them. Unlike Imran, Shehbaz has also acquitted himself well in offering succour to flood victims, even if only in terms of optics, by touring the flood-affected areas almost daily.

But the devastation caused by the floods on the one hand, and the potential for Imran Khan to cause disruption and political instability on the other, will not make his job any easier. ■